

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 40 Summary

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In this lesson, I cover the Spanish imperfect tense—one of the two primary past tenses along with the preterite. These two tenses are not interchangeable but work together to describe past events. This lesson shows you how to conjugate verbs in the imperfect, how it differs from the preterite, and how to use it to describe background actions, habitual behavior, and mental or emotional states.

1. Conjugating the Imperfect Tense

The good news: this tense is relatively easy to learn, with only three irregular verbs.

AR Verbs – Endings:

aba, abas, aba, ábamos, abais (Spain), aban

Example with *hablar* (to speak):

- yo hablaba – I was speaking / used to speak
- tú hablabas – you were speaking
- él/ella hablaba – he/she was speaking
- nosotros hablábamos – we were speaking
- ellos hablaban – they were speaking

ER and IR Verbs – Endings:

ía, ías, ía, íamos, íais (Spain), ían

(Note the accent on every form)

Example with *comer* (to eat):

- yo comía – I was eating / used to eat
- tú comías – you were eating
- ella comía – she was eating
- nosotros comíamos – we were eating
- ellos comían – they were eating

Example with *vivir* (to live):

- yo vivía – I lived / used to live

- tú vivías – you lived
- ella vivía – she lived
- nosotros vivíamos – we lived
- ellos vivían – they lived

Only 3 Irregular Verbs in the Imperfect:

1. **Ser (to be)**
era, eras, era, éramos, erais, eran
 2. **Ir (to go)**
iba, ibas, iba, íbamos, ibais, iban
 3. **Ver (to see)**
veía, veías, veía, veíamos, veíais, veían
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2. When to Use the Imperfect Tense

The imperfect is used when the action was:

- In progress in the past
- Repeated or habitual
- Descriptive (setting the scene or background)

A. Background Actions or Descriptions

Used to describe what was happening, what someone was like, or what the setting was.

Examples:

- *Yo caminaba por el parque cuando lo vi.* – I was walking through the park when I saw him.
- *La casa era muy grande.* – The house was very big.
- *Eran las ocho de la mañana.* – It was eight in the morning.
- *Hacía frío y llovía.* – It was cold and raining.
- *Tenía diez años.* – I was ten years old.
- *Estaba cansado y me dolía la cabeza.* – I was tired and my head hurt.

Why include the subject pronoun?

Because *yo estaba* and *ella estaba* both use the same form (*estaba*), context or adding the subject clarifies who you're talking about.

B. Ongoing Past Actions Using ESTAR + Gerund

You can describe what someone was doing at a specific time using the imperfect of *estar* + gerund.

Examples:

- *Yo estaba durmiendo cuando me llamaste.* – I was sleeping when you called me.
- *Estaba lloviendo cuando llegamos.* – It was raining when we arrived.

C. Repeated or Habitual Actions in the Past

This is how we say “used to” in Spanish.

Examples:

- *Yo comía pan todos los días.* – I used to eat bread every day.
- *Mi abuelo iba al parque todos los días.* – My grandfather used to go to the park every day.
- *Tú estudiabas en la tarde.* – You used to study in the afternoon.

Optional Construction with “SOLER” + Infinitive

Soler means “to be accustomed to” and is often used in the imperfect to say “used to.”

Examples:

- *Yo solía correr todos los días.* – I used to run every day.
- *Solía ver el coche.* – I used to wash the car.
- *Mi abuelo solía ir al parque.* – My grandfather used to go to the park.

This construction is very common and sounds natural, especially when the habitual action needs a little extra emphasis.

You will be using the preterite and the imperfect together to tell stories. There is a more detailed lesson about that in the intermediate section.